US support for Saudis against Houthis likely to remain indirect

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【メール原文】

US support for Saudis against Houthis likely to remain indirect. Houthi forces struck King Khalid International Airport in Riyadh on 11 October, killi

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Trump is hedging his bets on Texas
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Trump's diesel deal won't move prices or deliver an energy truce

US support for Saudis against Houthis likely to remain indirect. Houthi forces struck King Khalid International Airport in Riyadh on 11 October, killing at least 12, including one American citizen, and injuring over 300 more. Multiple airlines have paused flights out of Saudi Arabia in response.

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President Donald Trump has put the idea of US involvement against the Houthis back on the table, saying over the weekend that he is “going to look at” the possibility of joining an attack on the group. We assess, though, that direct military intervention from the US is unlikely, with Trump reluctant to become embroiled in another conflict in the Middle East.
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The US is already deeply intertwined in the conflict through indirect support – intelligence sharing, targeting assistance, and munitions – and previous operational failures against the Houthis under Trump remain a clear example of the potential downside of direct US military action.
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The airport attack does raise the political pressure on Trump to act further. Riyadh is likely to press Washington for deeper military commitment, especially if conditions on the ground deteriorate quickly. While direct US action is unlikely to occur in the short-term, primary watchpoints will be a potential Trump call to Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman, Houthi attacks on oil production infrastructure, and any changes to US force posture in the coming days.

Trump is hedging his bets on Texas. Trump is campaigning in Ohio and Alaska this week, with Politico reporting that MAGA Inc., the largest Trump-aligned super PAC, is focusing its spending on Ohio, Alaska, and Iowa in the final weeks of the campaign.

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These moves hint at what Republicans may be seeing as the endgame strategy to retain the Senate: acknowledge North Carolina as lost; lower the financial assistance to Ken Paxton in Texas; let Senator Susan Collins (R-ME) run her own, Trump-free, race in Maine.

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If Republicans lose all three while flipping no Democratic seats, they would retain Senate control with 50 seats, leaving Alaska, Ohio, Iowa, and Kansas as their Senate bulwark. Of those, Ohio and Alaska look equally vulnerable, with Democrats having consistently led by similar margins in both.

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This strategy might well be Republicans' most plausible route to retaining the Senate: The Alaska and Ohio races (along with the Texas one) obviously still hang in the balance, with plenty of room to move in the final three weeks of the campaign. But it's not a strategy with room for error; any failure in either state—let alone both—would probably hand Democrats the chamber. With the math now pointing in Democrats' favor, this narrow route for Republicans is key to our view that Democrats are moderate favorites to win the Senate (60% odds).

Trump's diesel deal won't move prices or deliver an energy truce. A durable energy ceasefire remains unlikely despite Trump's announcement that the US will buy diesel from Russia. Neither Moscow nor Kyiv appears to have committed to a proposed energy truce, and the Kremlin sees cold-weather strikes as central to forcing Kyiv into concessions. Escalation remains the basecase for the rest of the year.

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The US diesel purchases from Russia, together with the Treasury license running through 7 April, will barely affect US pump prices before the 3 November midterms. The first tranche of about 300,000 tons covers roughly half a day of US distillate consumption, and Russia's gains would equal at most about 0.05% of its GDP.

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The announcement of the deal is similarly unlikely to benefit Trump domestically: It has already led to serious pushback within the congressional GOP conference, and anything short of genuine price relief is unlikely to sway disaffected Trump voters in the midterms.

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The dispute about this deal is a setback, not a rupture, for US-Ukraine relations. It raises the risk that Washington cuts intelligence sharing and halts arms sales, but those threats carry less weight now that Europe provides more support. Another perceived US betrayal would likely strengthen President Volodymyr Zelensky at home and in Europe.

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For more, please see Trump-Putin deal won't impact diesel prices or produce an energy ceasefire , 12 October 2026.

Quote of the Day

"In the minority, we ran Pam Bondi out of town. In the minority, we ran Kristi Noem out of town. And I'm here to say one of the first things we're going to do in the majority is run Pete Hegseth out of town!" - House Minority Leader Hakeem Jeffries (D-NY) speaking at a rally this weekend; Jeffries has been noncommittal when asked whether Democrats will seek to impeach President Trump should they take the House, appearing to shift focus to targeting cabinet secretaries and other senior executive branch officials. Hegseth is likely to be at the top of that list, regardless of how his impeachment articles proceed after the midterms.

On the Radar

12-18 October: IMF and World Bank Annual Meetings

30-31 October: G20 Foreign Ministers' meeting

3 November: National midterm elections

9 November: Congress returns from recess

18-19 November: APEC leaders meeting in China

11 December: Government funding runs out

14-15 December: G20 summit in Florida

10 January: US-China tariff truce expires

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